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Travel Zoom Cameras

How to pick the right companion for your trip

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So you've got that all important vacation coming up, the one you've been planning for the longest time. And you discover that your camera is busted. Happened to me and after I was done raging about finding my camera busted right before the all-important trip, I used it as an excuse to buy myself a nice travel zoom. Cue in travel zooms that have a pocket friendly form factor and pack in a deviously large optical zoom lenses, all the while packing in newer features. However, it is a delicate balance between form and features. Before you decide to splurge on a travel zoom, there are a few things to keep in mind.

1) Megapixel Mischief:

Megapixel count has been one of the most effective marketing tools for camera makers to sell cameras. The notion that more megapixels mean more quality is quite deeply rooted, that is not the case. When considering a point-and-shoot, the best megapixel count lies between 12-16 megapixels. A funny story comes to mind here. I've often heard salesmen say, "Sirjee, this is 20 megapixel. Must better than 12 megapixel. You get 8 megapixels more for just 5K." After mentally facepalming myself a few times, I step in and put the spread of misinformation to rest.

2) The Tough Kid on the Block:

Going through the Butter-Finger syndrome is terrible, especially if you're holding a camera. We recommend buying something that feels sturdy and solid and not like cheap plastic. For example, the SZ7, which is a ridiculously slim travel zoom, however, the construction of the camera makes me want to put this thing in a case, and not my pockets. I was too worried about how it would get along with the contents of my pocket, and if it did decide

to wage war against the residents of said pockets, I was pretty sure it would lose. Bring in the Canon SX240 HS on the other hand and I wasn't worried a bit about letting it slide into the one pocket that contains enough change to put most beggars to shame.

3) Mine's bigger than yours:

The zoom rating on cameras might rock the same number, but there is a possibility that they are actually much different. The "x" number is determined by dividing the farthest a lens can zoom by the widest it can be. For example, a lens that can go from 25 mm on the wide end to 250 mm on the telephoto end has an optical zoom of 10x. Ideally, you want something that gives you a good wide end as well as a decent telephoto end. Ideally something between 25mm and 400mm. A perfect example is the Panasonic TZ-30 and the Sony HX-20V. Both have a "20x optical zoom tag", however, the Panasonic's zoom range is 24mm-480mm and the Sony frolics in the 25mm-500mm range. So on the side end, they're both very comparable, but on the telephoto end, that

20mm could make quite a bit of difference.

4) Cameras on a Powertrip:

One area where cameras have not seen much progress is the battery life. Most of these cameras are rated for about 200-250 shots on full charge (at best) so we strongly recommend buying extra batteries to boot. The Sony HX 20V currently claims the highest battery life (about 250 shots), but real life usage would considerably decrease that. Regardless, a few spares never hurt anyone (unless you chuck them real hard at someone, +50 points if it hits their face).

In conclusion, let me break it down for you and save your countless days' worth of online reading. If you're looking for an all-round performer, the Canon SX240 HS (or the SX260 HS as it has a GPS chip, but we don't like those) is my recommendation. The Sony HX 20V is a VERY good alternative, but is priced somewhat higher than the SX240 HS. If you're looking to cruise the currents that flow below the 15K mark, the Nikon Coolpix S8200 is a decent buy and if you're absolutely clear that you want something small, compact and light, then stick with the Panasonic SZ7. 

